launchpad for future success.

"I felt like this was a God-given opportunity for me, and I could not ignore it," he says of the visibility and confidence that he got from his run on the show, to which he would return as a mentor in 2022. "So I had to give it my all. I had also lost my job when I went to *Hustle*, so I had no option but to do music full-time."

That commitment to making music has paid off with three increasingly successful albums—*The Carnival* (2020) *The Gorilla Bounce* (2021) and last year's smash hit *Champagne Talk*—as well as a couple of cuts on Bollywood soundtracks. As his audience has grown, his music has also evolved in response, shifting from a more raw, bars-heavy approach to a more accessible pop sound. It's a trajectory that may not sit well with hip-hop purists, but King has no time for hand-wringing about genre. He makes no bones about the fact that he's been a massive pop fan since he was four years old, listening to Backstreet Boys and Vengaboys on a neighbour's radio set.

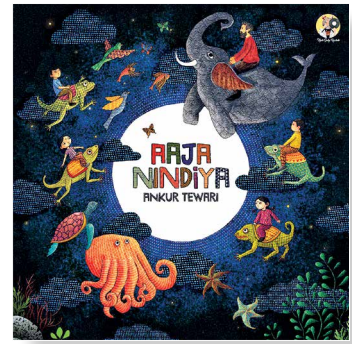
"The first three songs I ever wrote were a rap song, a pop song and an R&B song," he says. "My approach to making music is that a song is basically like *khichdi*: you can make it however you want, it just needs to taste good."

With his first international collaboration out of the way, King is now setting his aims even higher. "My immediate goal is a Grammy in 2024," he says with conviction. "I've always had global ambitions because I've always been a huge fan of guys like Justin Timberlake, Lil Wayne, Drake. These guys went from the streets to being global stars, so why can't I?" ■

Bhanuj Kappal

MUSIC

FOR THE RECORD



A NEW MUSIC LABEL, **TIGER BABY RECORDS**, LAUNCHES WITH AN ALBUM OF LULLABIES AND A PROMISE TO NURTURE INDIE TALENT

Tiger Baby Films' recently-launched Tiger Baby Records is the newest addition to a growing list of music labels from film production houses. Unlike most such labels, such as YRF Music for instance, which mostly release their parent companies' movie soundtracks, Tiger Baby Records plans to issue singles, EPs and albums by independent artists, as well as podcasts and music-centric documentaries.

The studio's co-founders, filmmakers Reema Kagti and Zoya Akhtar, see the label "as an extension of our storytelling". The pair enlisted frequent collaborator, singer-songwriter Ankur Tewari, to helm the enterprise, the inaugural release of which is *Aaja Nindiya*, a set of six Hindi lullabies by Tewari. It's the first of four children's EPs it will put out by the musician, whose discography includes *Bachcha Party*, a 2018 album of songs for kids.

"We want to be associated with different genres, sounds and soundscapes," says Akhtar, adding, "[there's] a gaping hole now in [original Indian] children's music." For Kagti and her, Tiger Baby Records serves as both another avenue for creative expression as well as an inhouse home for the music they have composed and curated for their productions. These have included the film *Gully Boy* (2019) and the web series *Made In Heaven* (2019–), for which Tewari was the music supervisor.

For Tewari, the label is a chance to provide indie musicians with the resources he didn't have access to at the onset of his own career over two decades ago. "I want to be that person for upcoming musicians [who is] helping and enabling [them] to concentrate on their work rather than on all the logistics of putting out music," he says. "We want to create a space for people where they can [focus] on writing songs, poetry and stories while we can, in a way, do the dirty work."

Upcoming titles include Tewari's next Hindi pop effort as well as a release by a female artist who has been signed to the label. "We also want to design bespoke music projects [where we] will have certain artists come in for just that particular album," says Akhtar. The nature of their deals too will be flexible. "We don't have a template as such," adds Kagti.



TIGER BABY RECORDS PLANS TO ISSUE SINGLES, EPs AND ALBUMS BY INDEPENDENT ARTISTS, AS WELL AS PODCASTS AND MUSIC-CENTRIC DOCUMENTARIES

But it's not a given that all of Tiger Baby Films' soundtracks will be on Tiger Baby Records. "That will be [decided] on a case-to-case basis, depending on how the film goes, who [we've] partnered with, who [our] co-producer is, and what's the best decision for that project," says Akhtar. ■

Amit Gurbaxani